Islam in World History: From the beginning to the 21st century



Can you identify this map? It depicts a part of Europe.

What is Islam, and who are Muslims? What is the significance of Islam in global history? Muslims make up a quarter of the world's population today, but what, if anything, do they share in common? This course begins with the origins of Islam as a local reform movement in the Arabian Peninsula in the 7th century and covers the history of how innumerable people across the globe came to describe themselves as its adherents. This is not a linear story of expansion and incorporation. Those calling themselves Muslims frequently fought one another ferociously while co-existing in peace with non-Muslims. Debates raged among them over how to be a good Muslim and the relationship of their faith to reason, science, religious practice, and political power. Today, learning about the history of Muslims is more important than ever in the context of an expanding global Muslim population and the rise of Islam as the vessel for international political and cultural movements. From the American perspective, studying this topic is relevant to understanding the experiences of Muslim Americans but also grabbling with our country's ongoing War on Terror and its post-Cold War foreign policy.

This class proceeds on a geographic and thematic basis and is divided into four roughly chronological parts. Themes include defining faith, mystical movements, women and patriarchy, the role of religion in commerce and empire, coexistence, variations in religious practice and identity, global intellectual movements, nationalism and liberalism, and the significance of Islam in America today. This is mainly a lecture course, although discussion will be incorporated into each session as well. Attending lecture is crucial, and there will be regular map quizzes.

Grade basis
20% Map quizzes These are simple exercises to improve your knowledge of historical geography. We will learn the material together and you will be expected to memorize it for the in-class quizzes.

25% Short paper Write a primary-source analysis (1,000-1,500 words) of Usama Ibn Munqidh, Evliya Çelebi, or another source that you clear with the instructor.

25% Mid-term exam

30% Final paper Explore the notion of the Muslim "world" using the readings we cover in the course. Was it a coherent concept, and if so, at what specific point in time, and why? You should anchor your argument in at least two specific case studies – that is, regions, texts, historical actors, or objects/commodities. It will be necessary to narrow your argument to a specific historical period.

Required texts (These will be on reserve in the library)
Fred M. Donner, *Muhammad and the believers: at the origins of Islam* (2010)
Vernon Egger, *A history of the Muslim world to 1750* (2017)
Usama Ibn Munqidh, *The book of contemplation: Islam and the Crusades* (2008)

Course schedule:

I: The beginning, 600-900

1 The global context

Lecture a What is religion and how can it be studied? Introduction to Islamic history
Lecture b Global antiquity: the collapse of Byzantine and Sassanid power

Readings
→ Fred Donner, *Muhammad and the Believers* (2010), 1-39.
→ Chris Wickham, *The Inheritance of Rome*, "The crystallization of Arab political power, 630-750" (2009), pp. 279-297 [*read for weeks 1 and 2*].

2 Muhammad's movement (map quiz, antiquity before Islam)

Lecture a The early believers and their struggles
Lecture b The Umayyads and the Abbasid Revolution

Readings
→ Chris Wickham, *The Inheritance of Rome*, "The crystallization of Arab political power, 630-750" (2009), pp. 279-297 [*read for weeks 1 and 2*].
→ Fred Donner, *Muhammad and the Believers* (2010), pp. 39-144; 189-224.

3 The Abbasids (map quiz, Abbasid realms)

Lecture a Abbasid Baghdad
Lecture b From Spain to Samarqand - the empire and its confines

Readings
→ Dmitri Gutas, *Greek Thought, Arabic Culture* (2006), pp. 1-27; 151-186.
→ Vernon Egger, *A history of the Muslim world to 1750* (2017), selection.

II: Expansion and encounters, 700-1300

4 Across the Mediterranean

Lecture a Muslim Spain and Italy
Lecture b The Crusades and the Reconquista in global context

Readings
→ Vernon Egger, *A history of the Muslim world to 1750* (2017), selection.
→ *Primary source*: Usama ibn al-Munqidh, *The book of contemplation: Islam and the Crusades*, selections.

5 Central and South Asia

Lecture a Islam and the Turks, the rise of Persianate culture
Lecture b The Ghaznavids, the Delhi Sultanate, and breaking into India

Readings
→ Nile Green, "Introduction: the frontiers of the Persian world," *The Persianate world…* (2019), pp 1-71.
→ Vernon Egger, *A history of the Muslim world to 1750* (2017), selection.

6 Expanding out of Eurasia

Lecture a Across the Sahara and into West Africa
Lecture b Indian Ocean Islam

Readings
→ Vernon Egger, *A history of the Muslim world to 1750* (2017), selection.
→ M.N. Pearson, "Muslims in the Indian Ocean," *The Indian Ocean* (2003), pp. 62-112.

III: Themes in Islamic history, through 1800

7 Interpreting the faith

Lecture a Islamic law and science
Lecture b Saints and Sufis

Readings
→ Azfar Moin, *The millennial sovereign: sacred kingship and sainthood in Islam* (2012), chapters 2 and 3.
→ *Primary source*: Ibn 'Arabi, *Perfect harmony: Sufi poetry of Ibn Arabi* (2003), selections; Mawlana Jalal al-Din Rumi, selections of poetry in translation.

8 Coexistence

Lecture a Mongol Eurasia and the *Pax Mongolica*
Lecture b Multi-religious empires: Ottomans, Safavids, Russians, and Mughals

Readings
→ Barkey, *Empires of difference: the Ottomans in comparative perspective* (2008)
→ *Primary source*: Evliya Chelebi, *An Ottoman traveler* (2010), selections on Central Europe and the Black Sea.

9 Commerce
(map quiz: Islamic empires of Afro-Eurasia)

Lecture a The Swahili Coast and Southeast Asia
Lecture b The impact of European maritime empires

Readings
→ Philippe Beaujard, *The Swahili World*, Jones and Laviolette, eds. (2017), Ch. 34, pp. 365-378.
→ Subrahmanyam and Thomaz, "Evolution of empire: the Portuguese in the Indian ocean during the sixteenth century," *The Political Economy of Merchant Empires* (1991).
→ *Primary source*: "Protocol at the Malaccan court," *Southeast Asian history: essential readings* (2013), pp. 84-90.

IV: Modern developments and Muslims today

10 Islamic modernities
(Map quiz: Afro-Eurasian trade)

Lecture a Crisis and reform at the end of the imperial age
Lecture b The 19th century: science, reason, and liberalism

Readings
→ Ali Yaycioglu, "Global Transformation of the Muslim World: Connections, Crises, and Reforms, 1680-1880" in Babak Rahimi, Armando Salvatore, and Roberto Tottoli eds., *The History of Islam* (in new series on History of Religion), Oxford: Wiley-Blackwell, forthcoming, 2017.
→ Seema Alavi, *Muslim Cosmopolitanism in the Age of Empire* (Cambridge, MA, 2015), pp. 169-221.

11 Nations and nationalism

Lecture a World wars and partitions
Lecture b Political Islam: Saudi Arabia and Iran

Readings
→ Tobi Jones, *Desert Kingdom: how oil and water forged modern Saudi Arabia* (2010), chapters 1 and 6.
→

12 Dealing with patriarchy

Lecture a Debates on women's rights over time
Lecture b Case study: women in Iran

Readings
→ Dominic Brookshaw and Nasrin Rahimiyeh, "Forugh Farrokhzad, Poet of Modern Iran: Iconic Woman and Feminine Pioneer of New Persian Poetry."
→ Aysha A. Hidayatullah, *The Feminist Edges of the Quran* (2014), pp. 1-21.
→ Deniz Kandiyoti, "Islam and patriarchy: a comparative perspective," *Women in Middle Eastern history* (1991), pp.23-42.

13 The post-Cold War world

a The War on Terror and America's military industrial complex
b Muslim Americans and the rise of identity politics

Readings
→ Bashir and Crews, eds., *Under the Drones: modern lives in the Afghanistan-Pakistan borderlands* (2012), selections.
→ Mustafa Akyol, "The creeping liberalism of American Islam," *NY Times Opinion*, Feb. 18, 2019.